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Choose Life: Nitzavim–Vayelech and the Daily Portions of 20 Elul

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The Daily Learning Portions

- **Chumash:** Parshat Nitzavim–Vayelech, 4th aliyah — Devarim 30:15–31:6
- **Tehillim:** Chapters 97–103 (Elul extra chapters: 58–60 per Hayom Yom / Baal Shem Tov custom)
- **Tanya:** Iggeret HaKodesh, latter part of Epistle 15
- **Rambam (3 ch.):** Hilchot Tum'at Tzara'at 14–16
- **Sefer HaMitzvot:** Daily cycle Day 212 — *tzara'at* of garments (impurity and communication of impurity); house-*tzara'at* is the center of today's three chapters
- **Hayom Yom:** Elul 20 — one who is lowly and crass does not sense his own crassness and lowliness

Seasonal frame. The twelve days continue. Elul 18 answered for Tishrei. Elul 19 answered for Cheshvan. The twentieth answers for Kislev of the year now ending. The King remains in the Field. The shofar is sounded. Three extra chapters of Tehillim are recited. Tefillin and mezuzot are checked in this month. Ashkenaz Selichot begin Motzaei Shabbat, 23 Elul / 5 September. Sephardic Selichot continue. On 19 Elul the Torah refused the alibi that the commandment is in heaven or across the sea. Today it places the same nearness under oath. Heaven and earth are called as witnesses. Life and death are set out. The verb is no longer "consider" or "do not send it on a voyage." The verb is *uvacharta* — choose.

I. The Fourth Aliyah: Life and Good Set Out, and the Transfer That Does Not Abandon

The third aliyah ended with the matter in the mouth and in the heart, to do it. The fourth aliyah does not add a new Torah. It makes the near commandment a choice that can be refused, and then it moves the staff from Moses' hand without moving the Presence.

> *"See, I have set before you today life and good, and death and evil." (Devarim 30:15)*

Rashi binds 30:15 to the next verse: life and good *are* loving Hashem, walking in His ways, keeping the commandments. Death and evil *are* the turning of the heart and the bowing to other gods. The pair is not two weather systems. It is one life, named from two sides. Ibn Ezra and Sforno read "see" as the demand that the eyes stay open. A choice unseen is not yet *bechirah*. It is drift.

> *"In that I command you today to love the Lord your G-d, to walk in His ways, and to keep His commandments, His statutes, and His ordinances, that you may live and multiply, and the Lord your G-d will bless you in the land which you come to possess. But if your heart turns*

> *away and you do not listen, and you are drawn away and bow to other gods and serve them, I declare to you today that you will surely perish; you will not lengthen days upon the land…" (30:16–18)*

The grammar is Elul's grammar. Love, walk, keep — then live. Turn, refuse to listen, be drawn, bow — then perish. Listening is again the hinge, as it was on 19 Elul. The land is not a prize detached from the walk. Length of days on the land is the walk made public.

Then the verse that is the day's banner:

> *"I call heaven and earth to witness against you today: life and death I have set before you, the blessing and the curse. Choose life, so that you and your seed may live — to love the Lord your G-d, to listen to His voice, and to cleave to Him, for He is your life and the length of your days, to dwell upon the land which the Lord swore to your fathers, to Abraham, to Isaac, and to Jacob, to give them." (30:19–20)*

Rashi (from Sifrei): why heaven and earth? If Israel says, "We did not hear," they will testify. And they are enduring witnesses. The fathers are named at the end so that the choice is not an invention of the chooser. It is fidelity to a gift already sworn.

Ramban and later *meforshim* linger on *ki hu chayecha* — He is your life. Cleaving is not metaphor stacked on biology. The life being chosen is not a mood called "spirituality." It is attachment to the One who is the life of the one choosing.

The aliyah does not close on the mountain. It turns to the man who has spoken.

> *"Moses went and spoke these words to all Israel. He said to them: I am a hundred and twenty years old today. I can no longer go out and come in, and the Lord has said to me, 'You shall not cross this Jordan.' The Lord your G-d — He will cross before you. He will destroy these nations from before you, and you shall dispossess them. Joshua — he will cross before you, as the Lord has spoken." (31:1–3)*

"Went and spoke" — Rashi: Moses went from the camp of the Levites into the camp of Israel to honor them. The teacher does not make the people climb to him on the last working day of his voice. He walks. Elul's King in the Field has a human image here without confusion of persons: the one who taught the choice now walks toward the choosers.

One hundred and twenty years old *today*. The word *hayom* again. Moses' completed measure and Israel's open choice stand in the same sentence. "I can no longer go out and come in" is not only bodily decline. Rashi reads it also as the wellsprings of wisdom closing at the decree. Leadership is not a permanent private store. It is a trust with a term.

> *"The Lord will do to them as He did to Sihon and Og, kings of the Amorites, and to their land, which He destroyed. The Lord will give them before you, and you shall do to them according to all the commandment which I have commanded you. Be strong and courageous. Do not fear and do not be broken before them, for the Lord your G-d — He is the One who goes with you. He will not fail you and He will not forsake you." (31:4–6)*

Chazak ve'ematz. The courage commanded is not the courage of a man who has replaced G-d. It is the courage of a people that must walk because G-d walks first. Joshua crosses. Hashem crosses. The two crossings are not competitors. Human succession under an accompaniment that "will not fail you and will not forsake you" is the constitutional sentence of the day.

Readings that must be kept distinct.

- *Peshat*: the covenant is now an open alternative with witnesses; Moses' term ends; Joshua is named; fear is forbidden because Presence does not expire with the first teacher.
- Rashi / Sifrei: heaven and earth as lasting witnesses; Moses honors the camp by walking toward it; wisdom's wells close at the decree, not only the legs.
- Mussar: *re'eh* demands sight. A coarse soul (today's Hayom Yom) does not see the two paths as two paths. It calls drift "life."
- Chassidic: *uvacharta bachayim* is the work of the Divine soul's middot when they are pointed at G-d alone (today's Tanya). Choosing life is not selecting a brand. It is directing *chesed, gevurah, tiferet, netzach, hod, yesod, malchut* toward Him.
- Civic-covenantal: witnesses, published alternatives, timed office, succession under higher law, courage that is not domination.

Elul reading. The portion of 19 Elul removed the fetch-excuse. The portion of 20 Elul removes the spectator-excuse. Nearness is not automatic obedience. Nearness is what makes refusal culpable and choice real. Kislev of the dying year is asked a hard question: where did I call inertia "faith," and where did I treat a teacher's departure as the departure of the One who goes before us?

II. Tehillim 97–103 and the Elul Chapters 58–60

The twentieth of the month is already kingship-psalms. Elul does not wait for Rosh Hashanah to say *HaMelech*.

Psalm 97 — "The Lord has reigned; the earth will rejoice." Cloud and thick dark are around Him; righteousness and justice are the foundation of His throne. Fire goes before Him. Idol-makers are shamed; Zion hears and is glad. The Field is not a picnic. It is a reign that has come close enough to be answered.

Psalm 98 — a new song, because He has done wonders. The same "today" that chooses life can sing what is not yet finished. The rivers clap. The mountains sing. Witnesses in 30:19 include more than human courts.

Psalm 99 — "The Lord has reigned; peoples will tremble." Moses and Aaron among His priests, Samuel among those who call. They called and He answered. Kingship here is not the erasure of intercession. It is the answering of it.

Psalm 100 — *Mizmor letodah.* Enter His gates with thanksgiving. The choice of life has a door that is gratitude, not panic.

Psalm 101 — David's house-rule: "I will sing of kindness and justice… I will not set before my eyes a base thing." Cheshbon for Kislev belongs in this psalm. A house that will not look at *devar beliya'al* is already emptying itself before the priest arrives (today's Rambam).

Psalm 102 — the prayer of the afflicted when he pours out his speech before the Lord. Choosing life does not require that the chooser already feel whole. The poured-out man is in the Psalter on the same morning as "choose life."

Psalm 103 — "Bless the Lord, O my soul." He forgives all iniquity. He redeems from the pit. "As a father has compassion on children, the Lord has compassion on those who fear Him, for He knows our frame; He remembers that we are dust." Elul's urgency sits inside this knowledge. The King in the Field is not a King who forgot dust. Compassion here is not the cancellation of the choice. It is the reason a dust-creature can still be commanded to choose.

The extra Elul chapters today — **58, 59, 60** — keep the house from becoming a slogan.

Psalm 58 asks the judges whether they indeed speak righteousness. Heaven and earth are not the only witnesses. Human judgment is on trial in the same month that commands *bechirah*. **Psalm 59** is deliverance from enemies who return at evening and growl like dogs. **Psalm 60** is the banner still to be raised after a hard field: "You have given those who fear You a banner to be displayed because of the truth." Kislev in the dying year remembers both the growl and the banner.

Elul and the table. Tell the children: Moses says "see" before he says "choose." Eyes first. Then the two paths. Then "He is your life." A child can understand that love is a walk, not a feeling that arrives by itself. Psalm 103: a father has compassion because he knows the child's frame. That is how to speak *bechirah* in a kitchen without terror.

III. Tanya — Latter Part of Iggeret HaKodesh, Epistle 15: Middot Directed to G-d Alone

The epistle has mapped the ten sefirot as they appear in the soul: lights and vessels; ChaBaD as root; the seven middot; *netzach* and *hod* as the grinding and contracting that let a recipient absorb what would otherwise remain "in heaven." Today's stretch turns the map from structure to direction.

Not only *chesed* toward G-d, but *gevurah* — fear of Heaven and rigorous keeping. *Tiferet* — to glorify G-d and His Torah in every way the soul can praise. *Netzach* — to prevail against whatever restrains service and cleaving. *Hod* — self-effacing praise and gratitude for favors already given. *Yesod* — binding to Him with desire and pleasure, as a father binds the teaching to the son so that the son actually receives it. *Malchut* — accepting the yoke.

The Alter Rebbe's point is not a catalogue. It is a diagnosis. The Divine soul is concerned with spiritual things alone, so that both inner love and outer *chesed* concentrate on Godliness. Worldly middot are the analogue, not the owner.

Elul reading. Hayom Yom of 20 Elul says that the coarse person does not sense his own coarseness. Tanya supplies the opposite portrait: a soul whose traits have an Owner. *Uvacharta bachayim* is this pointing. A man can keep busy with middot — generous, strict, beautiful, victorious, grateful — and still not have chosen life, because the traits are still circling the self. The King in the Field makes the pointing possible without requiring an ascent. Contraction on 19 Elul was for the recipient. Direction on 20 Elul is the recipient's answer.

Chinuch sits in *yesod* as the epistle describes it. A father who will not bind the teaching with desire leaves the child with a commandment that feels like 30:13 — across the sea. Choosing life is transmitted as attachment, not as a lecture on alternatives.

IV. Rambam, Tum'at Tzara'at 14–16: Empty the House Before the Looking

Chapters 14–16 turn from garments to houses.

A house in the Land, built as a house, of stones and wood and earth, can bear the mark — intense green or intense red, or spreading — on the measure of two *grisim*. The owner does not declare his own house. Even a sage who knows the signs says only, "Something like a *nega* has appeared to me in the house." The priest orders the house emptied *before* he enters to look, even bundles of wood and reeds, so that vessels — especially earthenware, which cannot be immersed back to purity — not become tamei by the pronouncement. Nothing in the house is defiled until the priest speaks. Mercy is written into the procedure. Then isolation, scraping, replacement of stones, plastering, watching for spread; persistent affliction can take the house down. Gentile houses, houses in the Diaspora, and certain unfinished or un-housed structures stand outside this law.

Rambam closes the treatise (16:10) with the sentence that gathers person, garment, and house: this discoloration in Israel is not a natural medical or architectural event. It is a sign concerning *lashon hara* and evil speech. The mark appears on walls after it has been practiced in the mouth.

Elul reading. On 19 Elul: a garment can carry the camp's wound, and return has a seventh day. Today: a house can, and the law requires emptying before judgment. Cheshbon hanefesh that announces "I already know what is wrong with my house" has skipped the sentence the owner must say. Self-certification is still not the rite. The priest's delay while the house is cleared is Elul's kindness: remove what you do not want included in the looking. *Lashon hara* is how a near commandment is made to rot the walls. Choosing life includes closing a mouth.

The King in the Field does not inspect by mood. He inspects by measures, after an emptying He Himself commanded.

V. Hayom Yom, 20 Elul: The Coarse Do Not Sense Their Coarseness

The day's teaching is short enough to miss and hard enough to end a year.

"One who is lowly and crass does not sense his own crassness and lowliness."

The Rebbe Rayatz said it on the request, "In Your abounding mercies, have compassion on us." We do not grasp either the soul's height or the depth of its descent into vanities. G-d knows both. We ask for compassion according to *His* understanding.

The same line is the law of *negaim*. "A person may observe all blemishes except his own" (Nega'im 2:5). An expert does not rule on his own affliction. He goes to another.

Why this over the Chumash of 20 Elul. "See, I have set before you" assumes sight. Hayom Yom names the ordinary failure of sight: coarseness is invisible to the coarse. Heaven and earth can be called as witnesses, and the man still will not see the two paths as two paths. That is why Elul is not only private inventory. It is bringing the house to a looking that is not self-issued. It is why the owner says "something like a *nega*," not "I have already judged my walls." It is why Moses walks into the camp instead of waiting for the camp to diagnose itself from a distance.

Kislev of the dying year is a good month for this line. Kislev holds hidden light and public dedication. Coarseness is the refusal to notice that the light was treated as ordinary.

VI. Approaches Held Together

1. **Legal-historical.** Devarim 30:15–31:6 is covenant as published alternative plus lawful succession; Rambam's house-laws are covenant as measured looking after commanded emptying.
2. **Exegetical.** *Re'eh* / *uvacharta* as sight then will; *ki hu chayecha* as attachment, not slogan; *chazak ve'ematz* as courage under accompaniment.
3. **Ethical-diagnostic.** Hayom Yom's unfelt coarseness; Psalm 101's refusal to set a base thing before the eyes; *lashon hara* as the speech that marks walls.
4. **Chassidic-practical.** Divine-soul middot pointed at G-d; King in the Field as the nearness that makes choosing possible; compassion asked according to His knowledge of our frame (Psalm 103 with Hayom Yom).
5. **Civic-covenantal.** Witnesses who outlast the speaker; timed office; succession that does not claim the Presence as private property; inspection by published measure; the owner forbidden to close his own case.

The constructive synthesis for this day: 19 Elul said the commandment is near. 20 Elul says nearness is a choice, and the chooser is the last person to trust as the sole inspector of his own coarseness. Empty the house. Direct the middot. Choose life so that the children live. Strengthen Joshua without imagining that G-d left when Moses' wells closed. He will not fail you. He will not forsake you.

VII. Practical Avodah and Chinuch

One avodah for 20 Elul. Today answers for Kislev of the year now ending. Do not audit the whole year. Ask two Kislev questions: where did I fail to *see* that two paths were in front of me, and where did I speak in a way that marked a house? Then do the verse. Say Devarim 30:19 aloud. Choose one concrete life — a blessing said without hurry, a sentence of *lashon hara* left unsaid, a strengthening word to a person who must now "cross" without the previous teacher in the room.

At the table. - Moses says "see" before "choose." Ask the children what they saw today that was life, and what was only drift calling itself life. - Heaven and earth are witnesses. That is not a threat for a child. It is the world being asked to remember a good choice. - A person does not rule on his own *nega*. In a family that means: we help each other see. We do not perform humiliation. We also do not let coarseness call itself self-knowledge.

Family note for the twelve days. Elul 18 = Tishrei. 19 = Cheshvan. **20 = Kislev.** 21 = Tevet. 22 = Shevat. 23 = Adar. 24 = Nisan. 25 = Iyar. 26 = Sivan. 27 = Tammuz. 28 = Av. 29 = Elul. Keep the list on paper. Do not perform it.

What not to do. Do not use “choose life” as a club at the table. Do not use Hayom Yom’s line as license to diagnose everyone else while remaining unexamined. Do not treat Moses’ departure as abandonment. The verse forbids that reading in advance: He will not fail you and He will not forsake you.

VIII. Covenantal-Republican Resonance (only where the text already speaks)

Free will in this aliyah is not a modern slogan placed onto Torah. It is the structure of 30:15–19. Alternatives are published. Witnesses are named. The chooser is addressed as one who can refuse. Consent that cannot refuse is not consent. *Bechirah* is the ground of return because return is a chosen walk back toward a life that was already set out.

Non-domination appears in the succession. Moses cannot cross. Joshua will. Hashem crosses first. No human office swallows the Presence. Timed leadership under a higher accompaniment is the opposite of a man who cannot be replaced and therefore cannot be limited.

Limited power under higher law is the priest’s mouth in the house-laws. The owner may not close the case. The priest may not look until the house is emptied. Pronouncement, not private certainty, changes the status of the vessels. Measures — two *grisim*, colors named — bind the inspector.

Civic transmission is Moses walking into the camp, Tanya’s *yesod* as binding the teaching to the child, and “so that you and your seed may live.” A republic of the covenant that stores choosing in specialists has already put life across the Jordan without Joshua.

Courage — *chazak ve’ematz* — is commanded after the accompaniment is promised, not instead of it. That is not softness. It is the only kind of civic strength that does not become another idol.

IX. Extended Bibliography

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Tehillim - Psalms 97–103; Elul chapters 58–60. Sefaria, Psalms 97

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Elul / High Holiday - Likkutei Torah and classic Elul discourses on the King in the Field (Alter Rebbe). - Rambam, Hilchot Teshuvah 5 (free will as foundation of command, reward, and return) — the doctrinal companion of *uvacharta bachayim*. - Rambam, Hilchot Teshuvah 7 (teshuvah's reach).

Covenantal-republican (only as resonance, not as replacement of peshat) - Philip Pettit, *Republicanism: A Theory of Freedom and Government* (non-domination as freedom from arbitrary power). - Eric Nelson, *The Hebrew Republic* (Hebraic sources in early modern republican thought). - Deuteronomy's own constitutional pattern: published law, witnesses, limited office, succession, courage under higher accompaniment.

Daily study portals - Chabad.org Daily Study - Chabad.org Hayom Yom

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